

# Who are the Food Processing Workers in South Asia?

**Inputs for SAPLING High-Level Policy Dialogue:  
“Unlocking Value: Advancing Food Processing for  
Employment Generation and Sustainable Growth in SAR”**

South Asia People team

June 5, 2026



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## **Definition of food processing workers**

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# Definition of food processing workers

*(All definitions used for this study are the ones developed by the Global Jobs and Growth team)*

## Proposed ISIC Rev. 4 mapping (work in progress)

**Key Assumption:** Sectoral weights derived from employment data are assumed to be applicable to value-added data.

### Infrastructure and Energy

- **Employment:** ISIC divisions 35-39 (utilities), 41-43 (construction), and 61 (telecommunication).
- **Output:** ISIC sections D, E, F (35-39; 41-43), weighted ISIC section J (to extract telecommunication).
- **Justification:** Jobs Council Minutes.

### Healthcare

- **Employment:** ISICs sectors 86-88 (human health and social work)
- **Output:** ISIC section Q (86-88)
- **Justification:** Jobs Council Minutes.

### Agribusiness (more details next section)

- **Employment:** Wage employment in 01 (crop and animal), 02 (forestry) and 03 (fishing); all employment in 10 (manufacture of food), 11 (manufacture of beverages), and 12 (manufacture of tobacco).
- **Output:** Weighted ISIC section A and weighted section C.
- **Justification:** : Jobs Council Minutes, reports & literature.

### Manufacturing

- **Employment:** ISIC sectors 13-33 (all manufacturing sectors minus agribusiness)
- **Output:** Weighted ISIC section C.
- **Justification:** Jobs Council Minutes.

### Tourism (more details next section)

- **Employment:** It is recommended to use ILO reported tourism employment directly. When such data is not available, weighted shares are derived from ISICs sectors 49 (land transport), 50 (water transport), 51 (air transport), 55 (accommodation), 56 (food and beverages), 68 (real estate activities), 77 (rental), 79 (travel agency), 90 (arts and recreation), 91 (cultural activities), 92 (gambling), and 93 (recreation), using the MIC or LIC average of countries with tourism data.
- **Output:** Weighted ISIC sections of H, I, N and R.
- **Justification:** : Jobs Council Minutes and ILO.

\* Note: Employment data are reported at ISIC division level (2-digit) in ILO, while GDP data, in most cases, are only reported at the ISIC section level (e.g., A, B, C). Therefore, the proposed mapping is done at different levels. Weights are applied in value added when there is a lack of aggregates by detailed sectors.

## Agribusiness

- “Agribusiness refers to the business sector encompassing farming and farming-related commercial activities, including the supply of agricultural inputs, the production and transformation of agricultural products, and their distribution to final consumers.” – FAO
- Key characteristics compared to subsistence agriculture
  - Formal/wage employment ([McCullough, 2017](#))
  - High productivity ([Sollin et al., 2014](#))
  - Market-oriented ([WDR, 2008](#))
  - Organized ([FAO, 2014](#))
  - Capital-intensive ([FAO, 2017](#))
  - Value-chain integration ([FAO, 2014](#))
- Operationalization based on key characteristics
  - **Current strategy:** Wage employment in agriculture sector (as a proxy of ‘modern agriculture’) plus manufacturing of food products, beverages, and tobacco in the manufacturing sector. But the limitation of using a wage-based breakdown is that it does not allow us to identify output.
  - **Alternative strategy:** Again, the core idea is to break down agriculture into ‘traditional’ and ‘modern’ components, allocating the modern share to ‘agribusiness.’ A crude method for this classification relies on a threshold—defined as **x% of average HIC labor productivity in agriculture**. Under this approach, countries with agricultural productivity above the threshold are classified entirely as ‘modern’ in terms of both value added and employment, while those below are classified as ‘traditional.’

**Source:** Global Jobs and Growth team.

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## Definition of food processing workers

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- All definitions of workers used in this study follow those compiled by the Global Jobs and Growth team and rely on International Standard Industrial Classification of All Economic Activities (ISIC) codes at 2-digit level.
- Food processing workers include:
  - Economic activity (ISIC-Rev.4), 2-digit level: 10 - Manufacture of food products
  - Economic activity (ISIC-Rev.4), 2-digit level: 11 - Manufacture of beverages

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**Data**

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## Data – Supply side

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- Microdata from **Labor Force Surveys and Household Surveys**
  - Nationally representative surveys
  - Collected by the National Statistical Offices
  - Years: Circa 2023
  - Harmonized data in the WBG's Global Labor Database (GLD) data repository
- Collects information on household characteristics, individual demographics, education characteristics of respondents, as well as labor market information

## Data – Supply side

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| Country    | Survey name                             | Year    |
|------------|-----------------------------------------|---------|
| Bangladesh | Quarterly Labour Force Survey           | 2022    |
| Bhutan     | Labour Force Survey                     | 2022    |
| India      | Periodic Labour Force Survey            | 2023/24 |
| Maldives   | Household Income and Expenditure Survey | 2019    |
| Nepal      | Living Standards Survey                 | 2022/23 |
| Sri Lanka  | Labour Force Survey                     | 2023    |

**Source:** Own elaboration.

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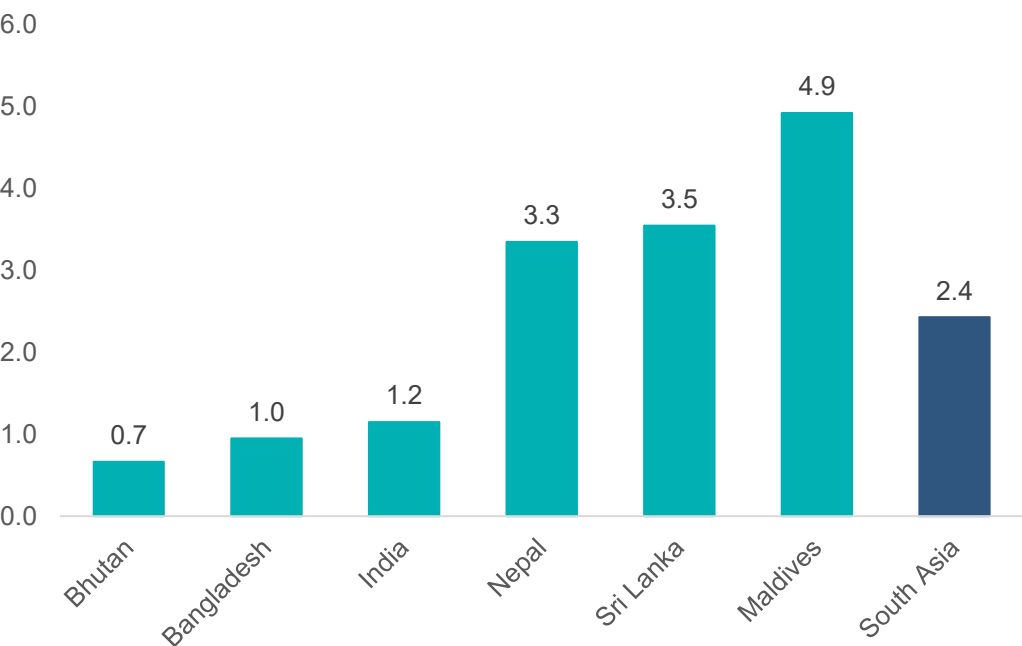
# **Profiling food processing workers in South Asia**

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Food processing accounts for about 2.4 percent of total employment in South Asia, equivalent to roughly 7 million workers. While still a small part of the labor market, the sector is strategically important because it sits at the intersection of agriculture, manufacturing, and jobs.

Share of workers in the food processing sector in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

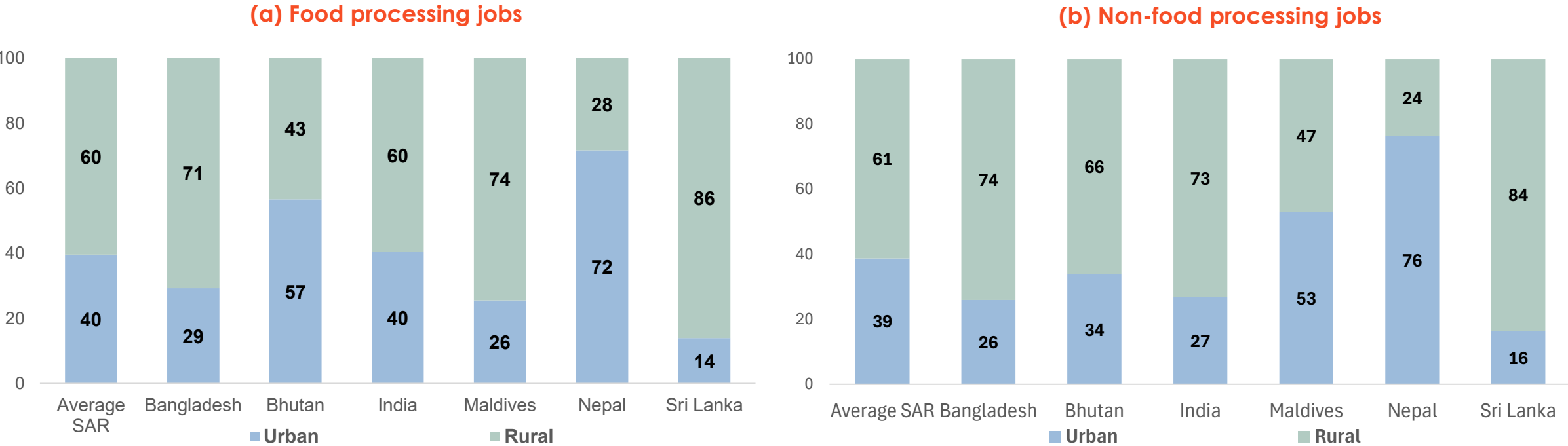
Share and number of workers in the food processing and rest of sectors in South Asia, circa 2023

| Country    | Share of workers |                 | Number of workers |                 |
|------------|------------------|-----------------|-------------------|-----------------|
|            | Food processing  | Rest of sectors | Food processing   | Rest of sectors |
| Bhutan     | 0.7              | 99.3            | 1,892             | 283,375         |
| Bangladesh | 1.0              | 99.0            | 633,141           | 66,001,734      |
| India      | 1.2              | 98.8            | 5,573,080         | 478,908,389     |
| Nepal      | 3.3              | 96.7            | 225,491           | 6,509,213       |
| Sri Lanka  | 3.5              | 96.5            | 284,121           | 7,725,817       |
| Maldives   | 4.9              | 95.1            | 8,889             | 171,679         |
| South Asia | 2.4              | 97.6            | 6,726,614         | 559,600,207     |

**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

Food processing jobs remain predominantly rural in South Asia overall. This makes the sector relevant not only for industrial and urban employment strategies, but also for creating non-farm opportunities closer to agricultural communities.

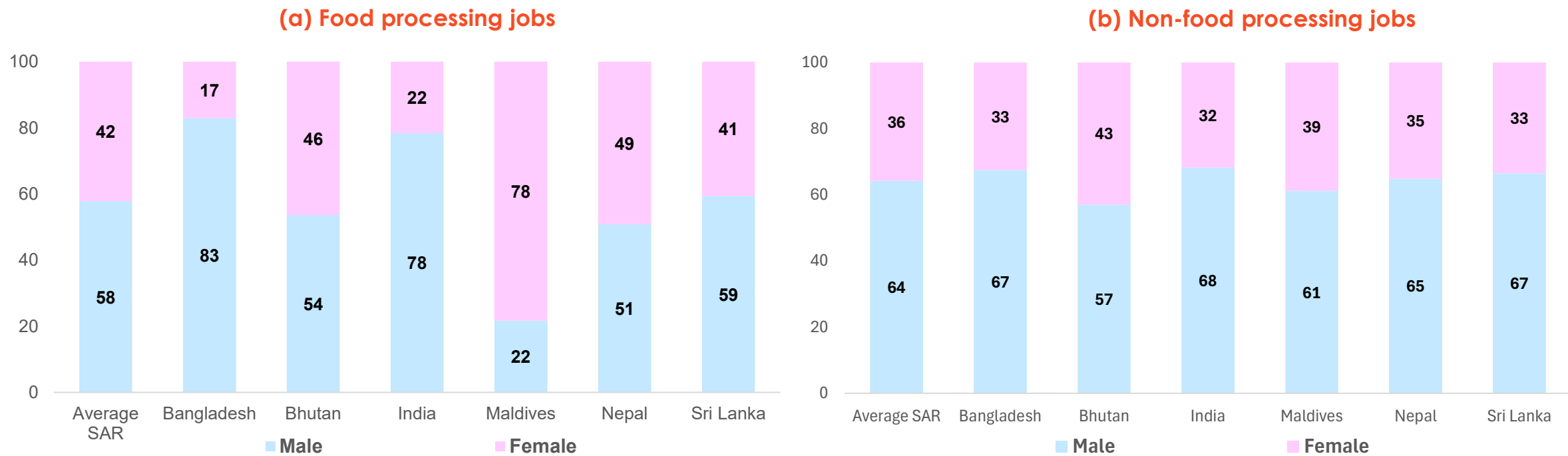
Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by area of residence in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). In the Maldives, 'urban' corresponds to 'Malé', and 'rural' to the 'Atolls'. The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

Women account for a higher share of employment in food processing than in the rest of the labor market. This suggests that food processing can be an important entry point for expanding women’s access to non-farm work, although patterns vary substantially across countries.

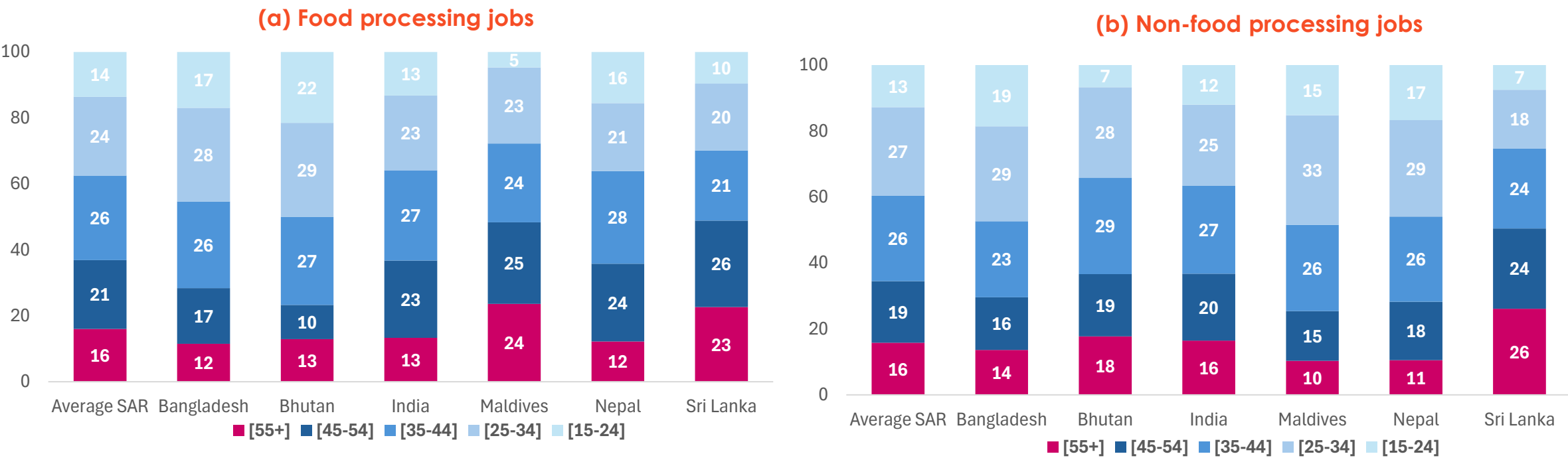
Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by gender in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

Youth account for only a modest share of food processing employment. Skills strategies should therefore serve both new labor market entrants and, importantly, adults already working in the sector who may need upskilling or reskilling.

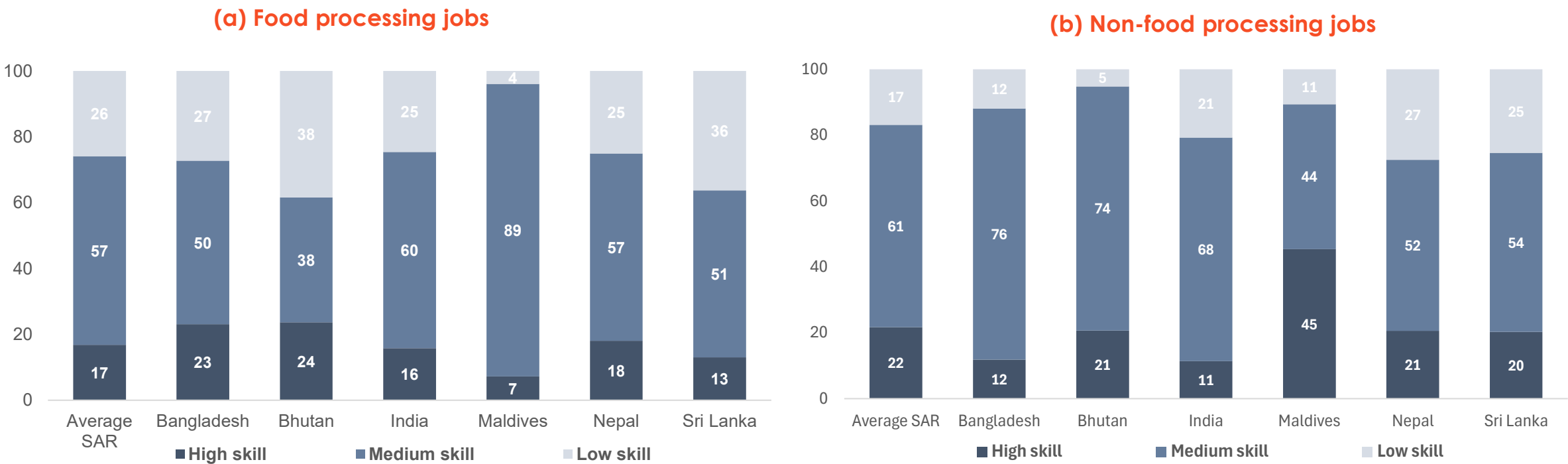
Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by age group in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

Most food processing workers are employed in medium-skill occupations, while low-skill jobs still account for about one-quarter of employment. Bangladesh and Bhutan have the highest shares of high-skill workers in food processing, while the Maldives has the lowest.

Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by occupational skill category in South Asia, circa 2023

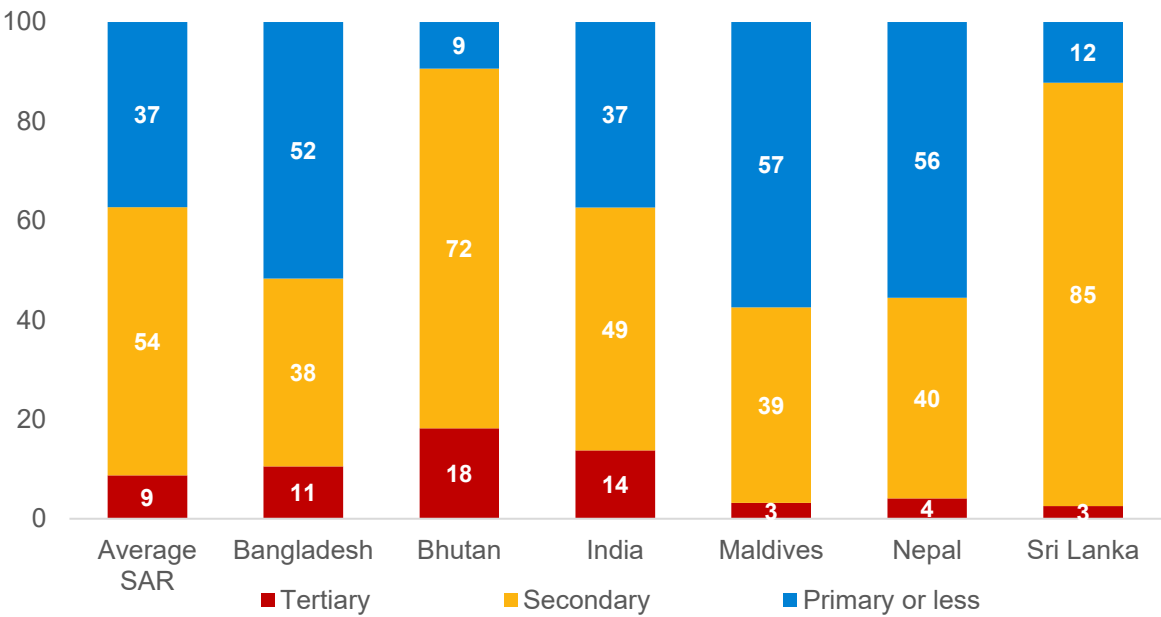


**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

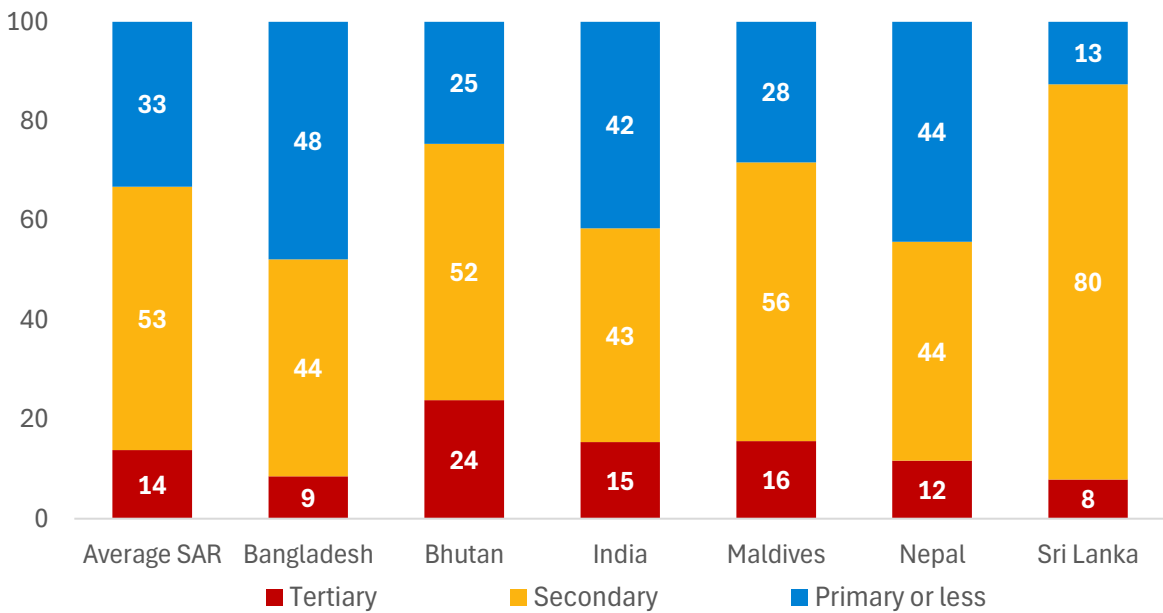
Most food processing workers in the region have secondary education or less, so skills programs need to be short-cycle, practical, and accessible to workers without long formal education pathways.

Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by education level in South Asia, circa 2023

(a) Food processing jobs

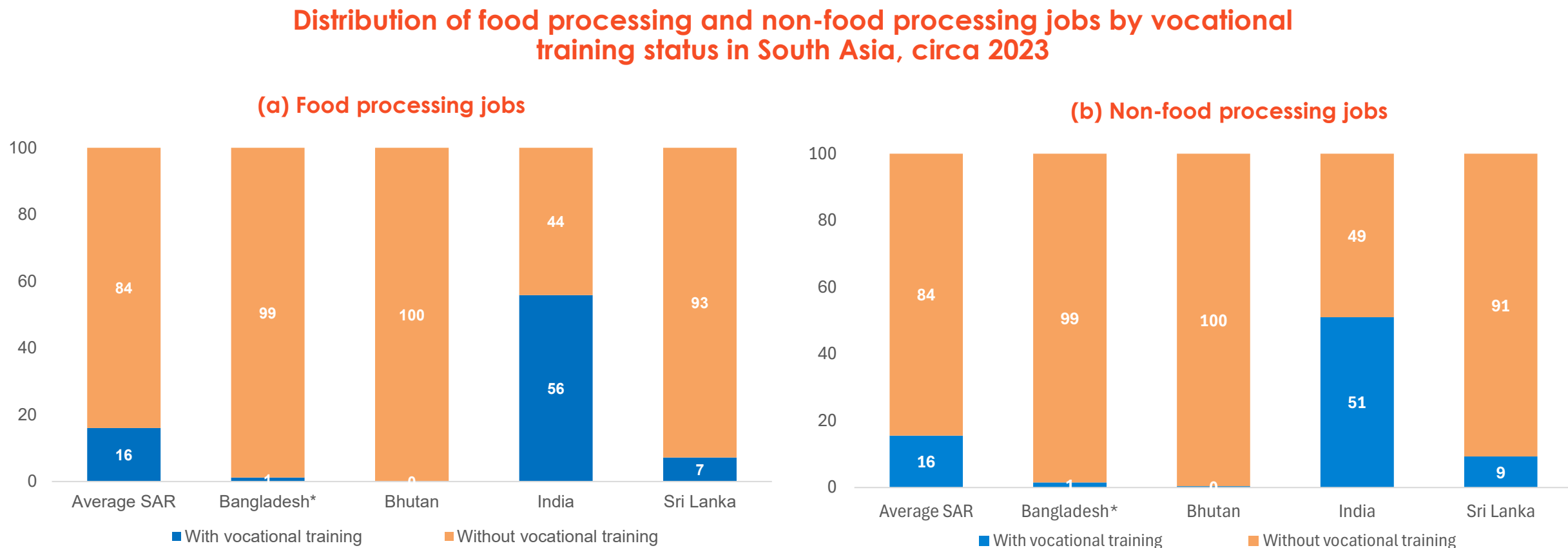


(b) Non-food processing jobs



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

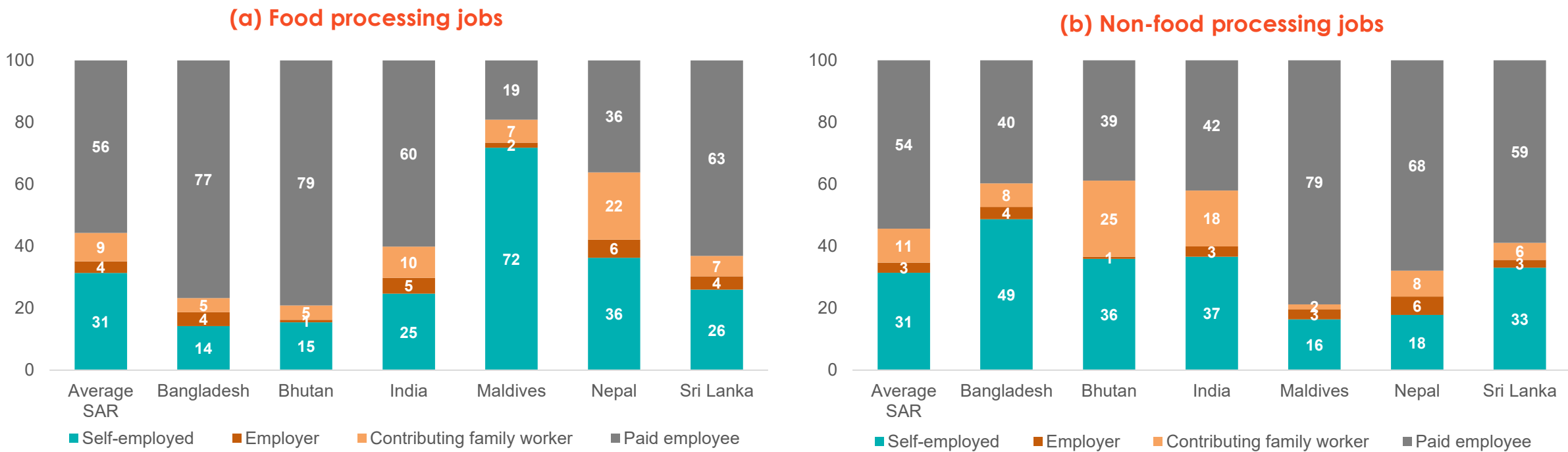
Most food processing workers in the region have not received vocational training. India stands out with higher training coverage, but in most countries, training remains limited or nearly absent, suggesting a large opportunity to expand job-relevant skills provision.



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Maldives and Nepal are not included because they do not provide comparable data on vocational training status. The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

Food processing is slightly more oriented toward paid employment than other sectors, but self-employment remains important in several countries. While paid employment dominates in most countries, self-employment remains a major part of the sector, especially in the Maldives and Nepal.

Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by employment status group in South Asia, circa 2023

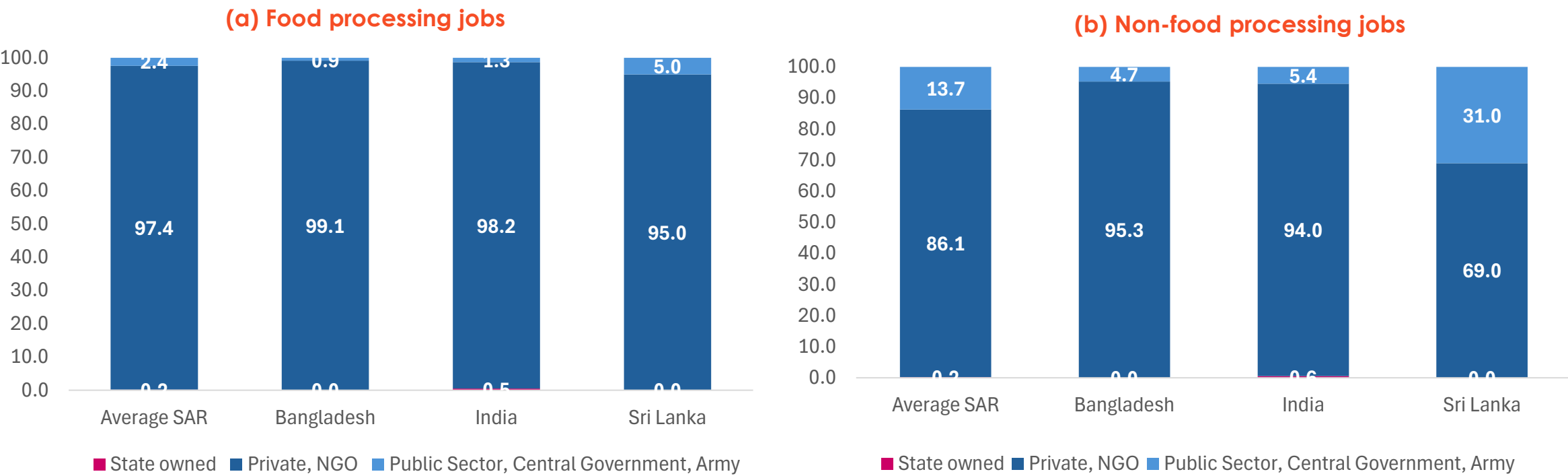


**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.



Food processing employment is concentrated almost entirely in the private sector. This reinforces the importance of employer engagement and firm-linked training models.

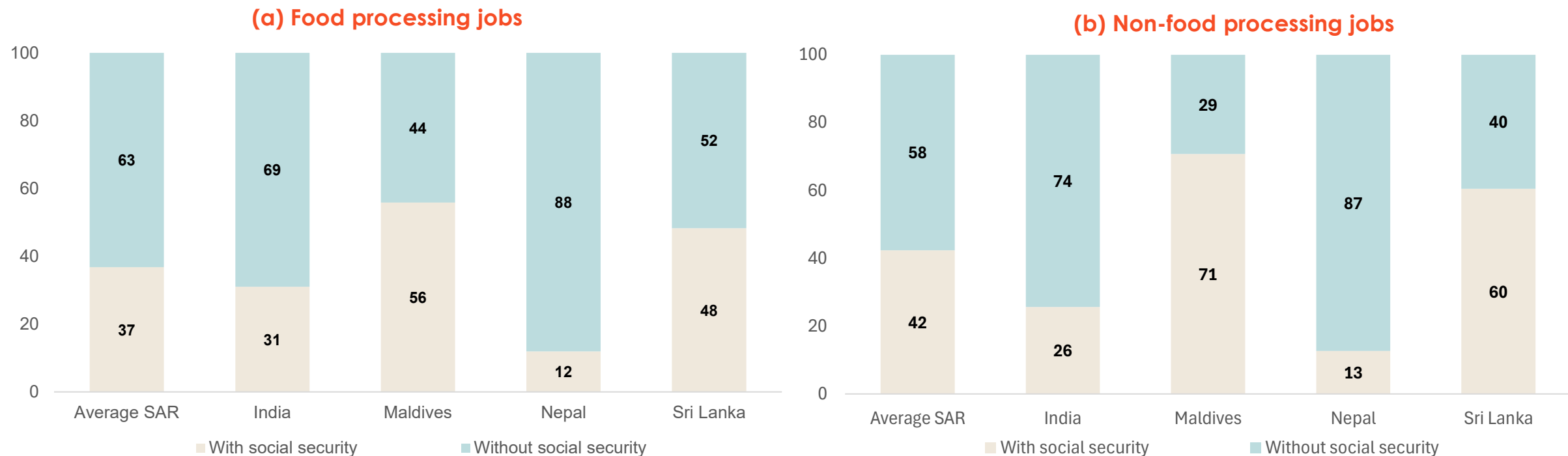
Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by sector of activity in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Bhutan, the Maldives, and Nepal are not included because they do not provide comparable data on the sector of activity. The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

Food processing creates wage employment opportunities, but many of these jobs remain weakly protected. A large share of paid employees lack social security coverage or written contracts, highlighting the need to connect skills strategies with better job quality.

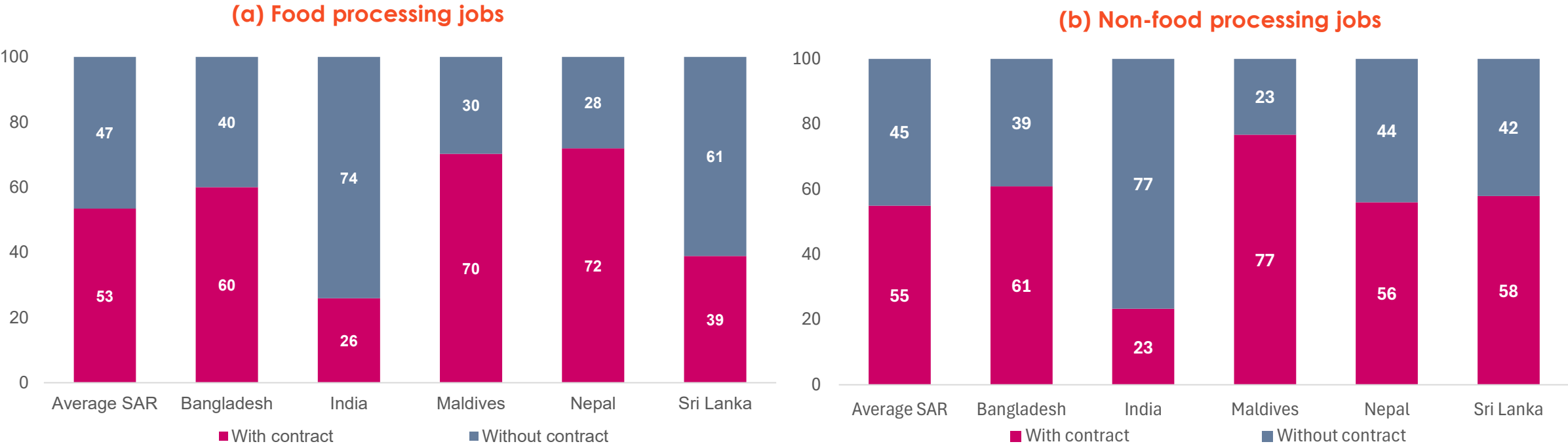
Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by social security contributions at work (employees only) in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). . The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Bangladesh and Bhutan are not included because they do not provide comparable data on social security contributions at work. The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

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Distribution of food processing and non-food processing jobs by the presence of a written labor contract (employees only) in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Bhutan is not included because it does not provide comparable data on written labor contract for employees. The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country.

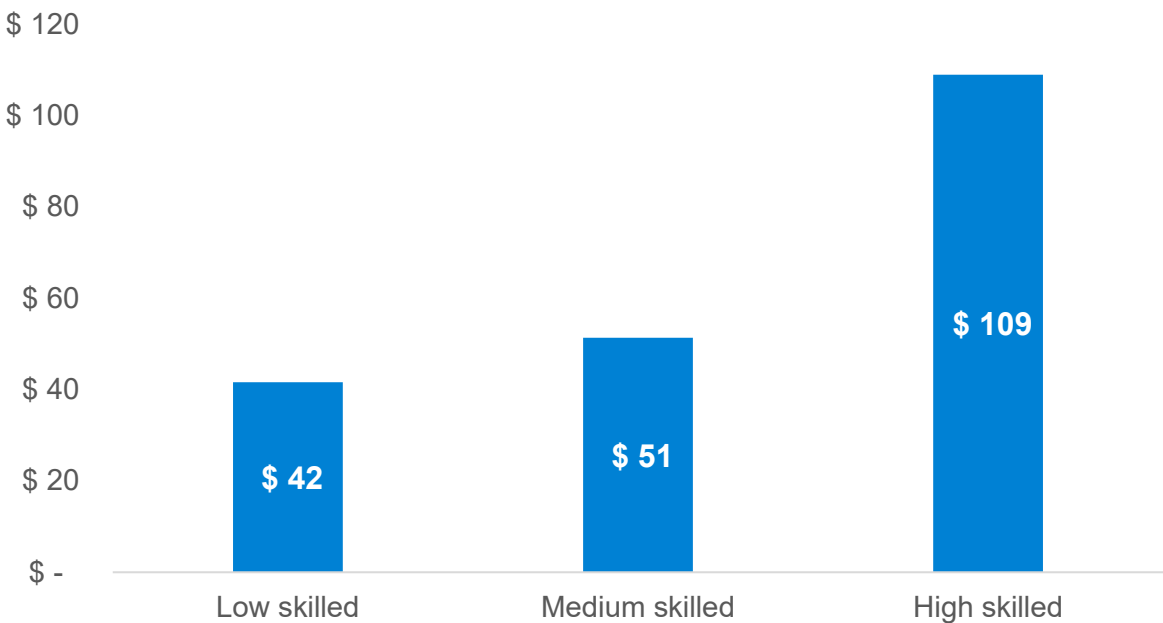
Food processing workers earn slightly less on average than non-food-processing workers. However, wages rise strongly with skill level, suggesting that helping workers move into higher-skilled roles could make a meaningful difference for earnings.

Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers in Bangladesh (in local currency), 2022



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable.

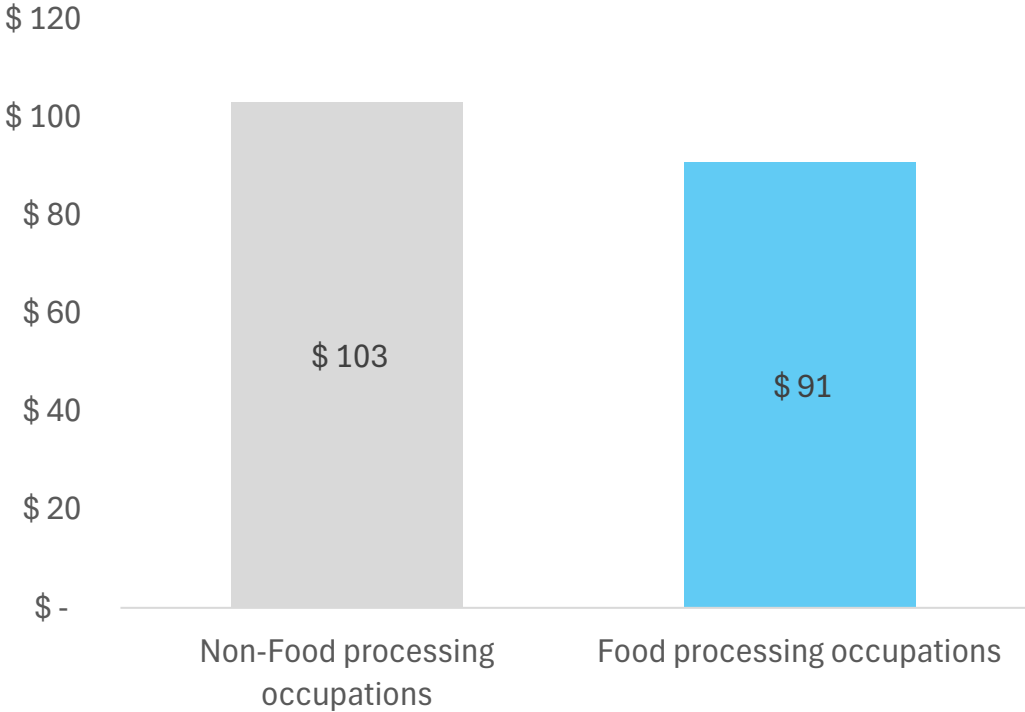
Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers by skill level in Bangladesh (in local currency), 2022



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable. Skilled occupations correspond to ISCO major groups 1, 2, and 3 (Managers, Professionals, Technicians); semi-skilled occupations to groups 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 (Clerical support, Service & sales, Skilled agricultural, Craft & related trades, Plant & machine operators); and unskilled occupations to group 9 (Elementary occupations).

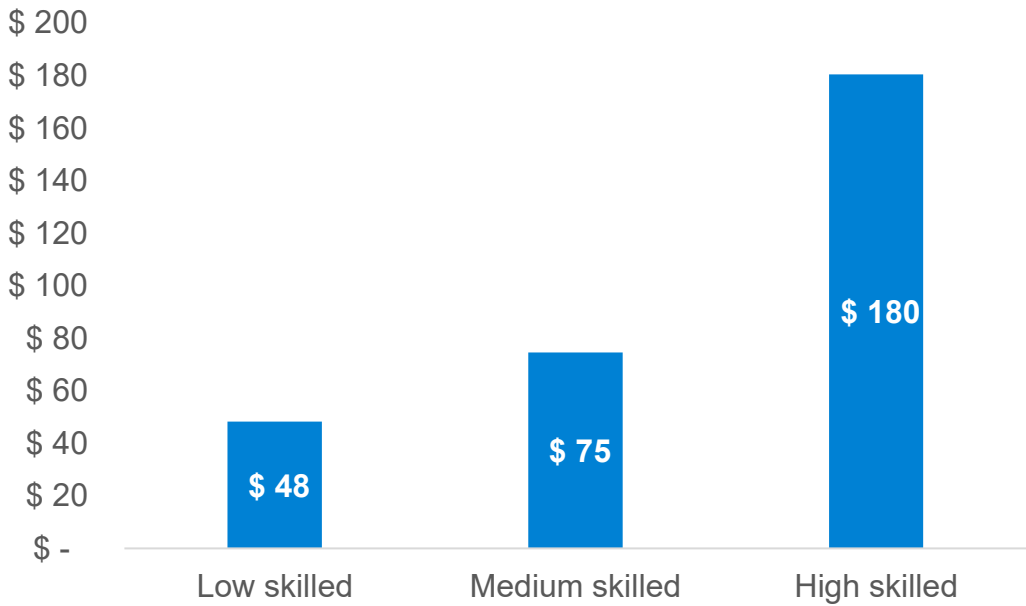
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Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers in Bhutan (in local currency), 2022



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bhutan LFS (2022). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable.

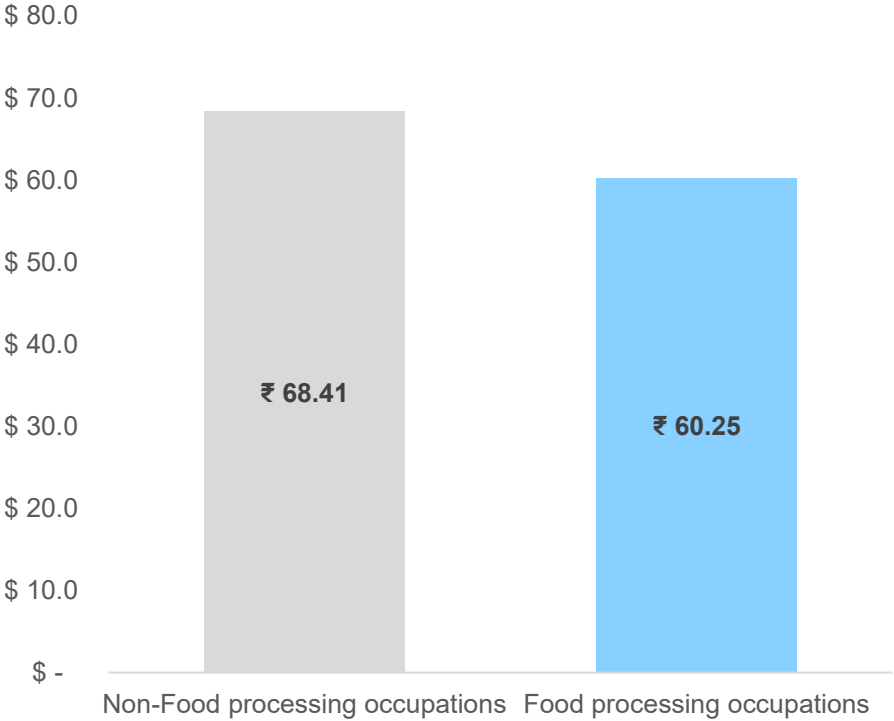
Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers by skill level in Bhutan (in local currency), 2022



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bhutan LFS (2022). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable. Skilled occupations correspond to ISCO major groups 1, 2, and 3 (Managers, Professionals, Technicians); semi-skilled occupations to groups 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 (Clerical support, Service & sales, Skilled agricultural, Craft & related trades, Plant & machine operators); and unskilled occupations to group 9 (Elementary occupations).

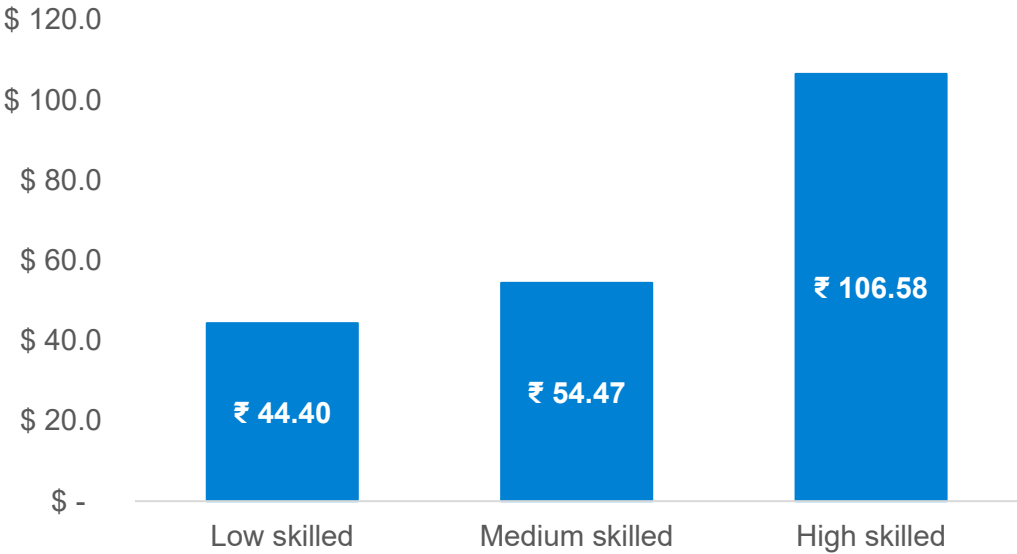
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Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers in India (in local currency), 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable.

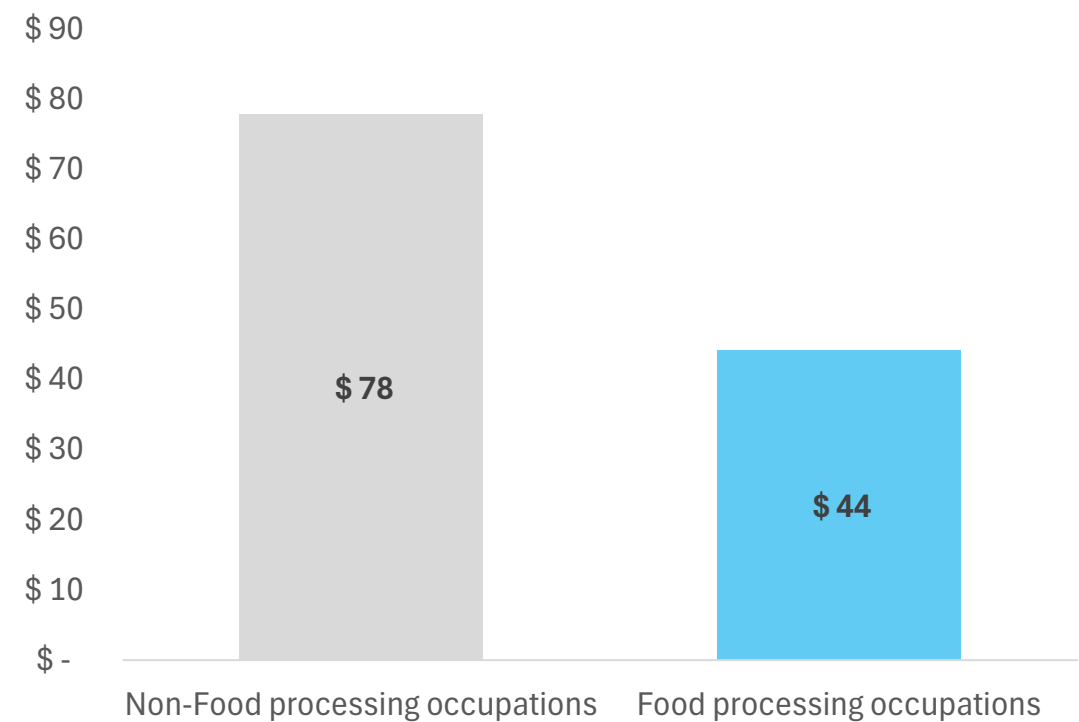
Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers by skill level in India (in local currency), 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable. Skilled occupations correspond to ISCO major groups 1, 2, and 3 (Managers, Professionals, Technicians); semi-skilled occupations to groups 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 (Clerical support, Service & sales, Skilled agricultural, Craft & related trades, Plant & machine operators); and unskilled occupations to group 9 (Elementary occupations).

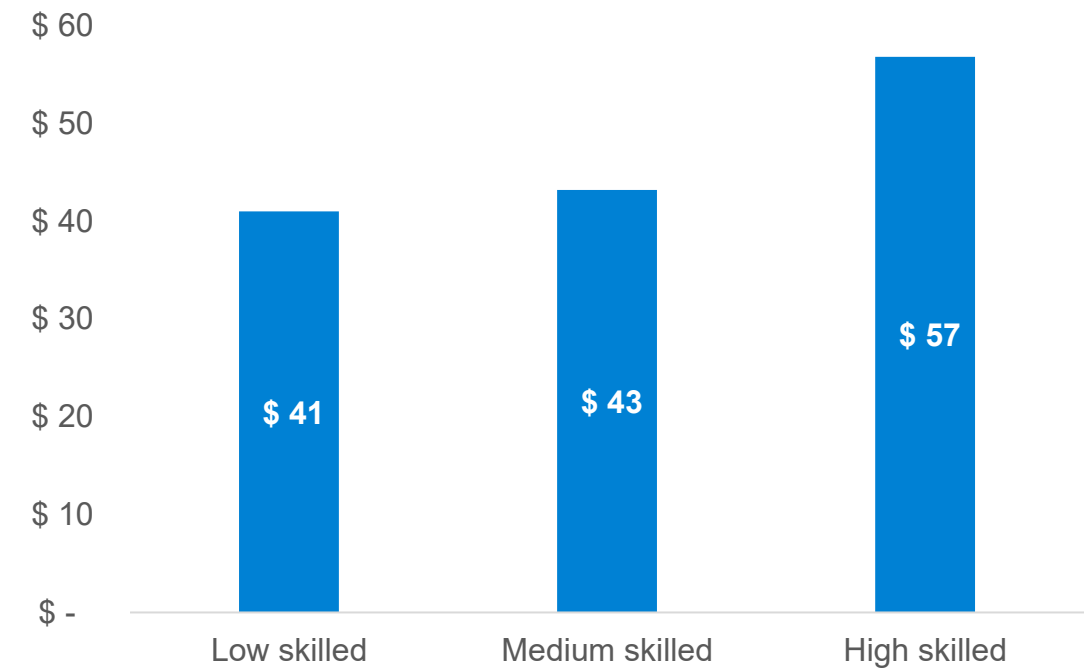
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Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers in the Maldives (in local currency), 2019



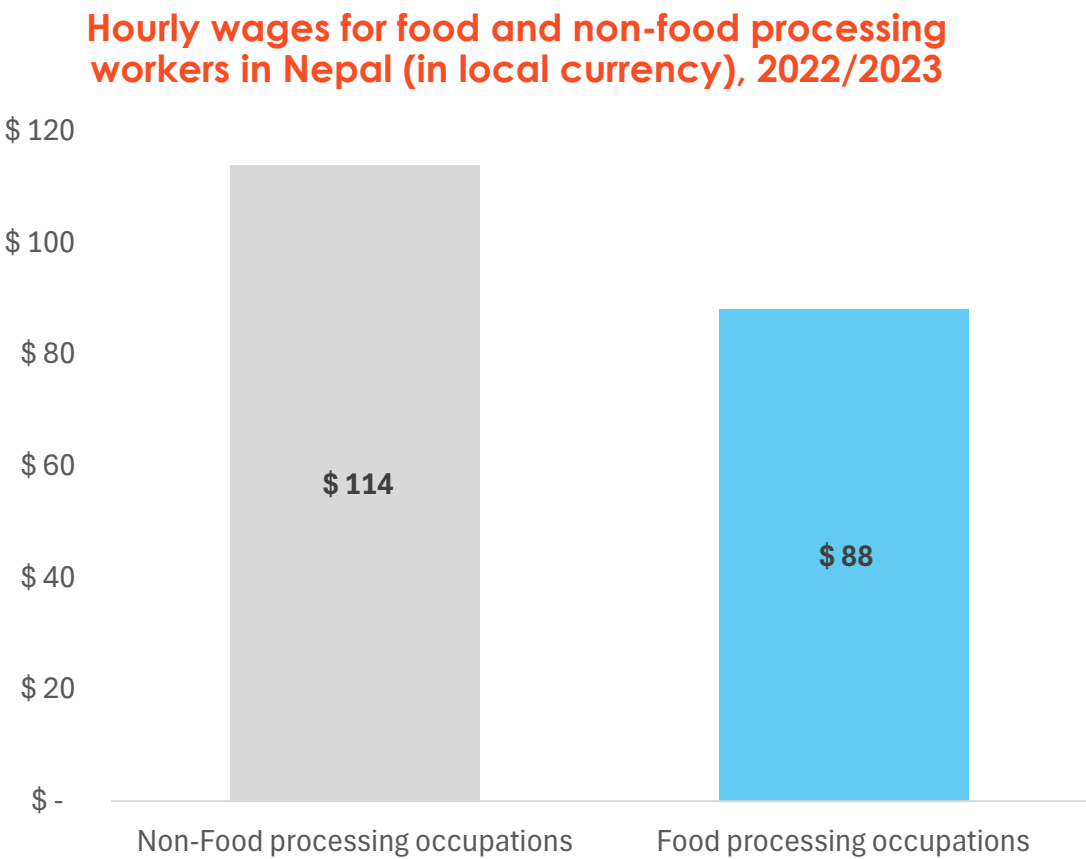
**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Maldives HIES (2019). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable.

Hourly wages for food and non-food processing workers by skill level in the Maldives (in local currency), 2019



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Maldives HIES (2019). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable. Skilled occupations correspond to ISCO major groups 1, 2, and 3 (Managers, Professionals, Technicians); semi-skilled occupations to groups 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 (Clerical support, Service & sales, Skilled agricultural, Craft & related trades, Plant & machine operators); and unskilled occupations to group 9 (Elementary occupations).

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**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Nepal LSS 2022/23. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable.



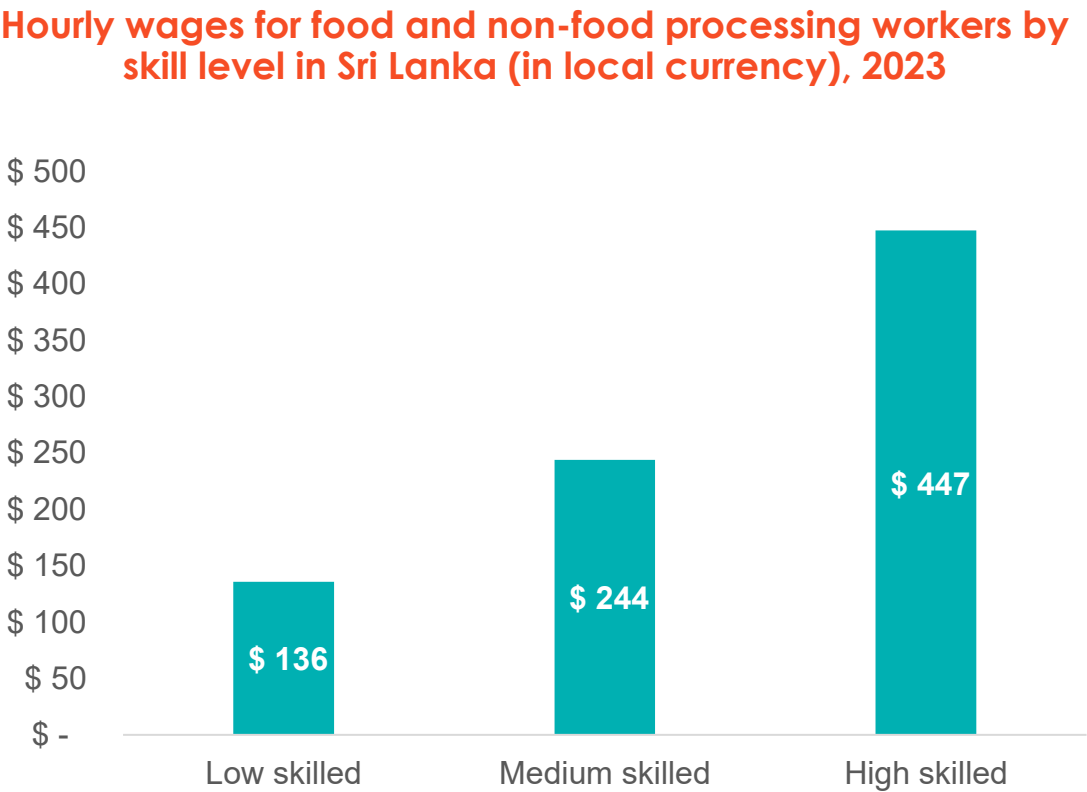
**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Nepal LSS 2022/23. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable. Skilled occupations correspond to ISCO major groups 1, 2, and 3 (Managers, Professionals, Technicians); semi-skilled occupations to groups 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 (Clerical support, Service & sales, Skilled agricultural, Craft & related trades, Plant & machine operators); and unskilled occupations to group 9 (Elementary occupations).



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**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable.



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable. Skilled occupations correspond to ISCO major groups 1, 2, and 3 (Managers, Professionals, Technicians); semi-skilled occupations to groups 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 (Clerical support, Service & sales, Skilled agricultural, Craft & related trades, Plant & machine operators); and unskilled occupations to group 9 (Elementary occupations).

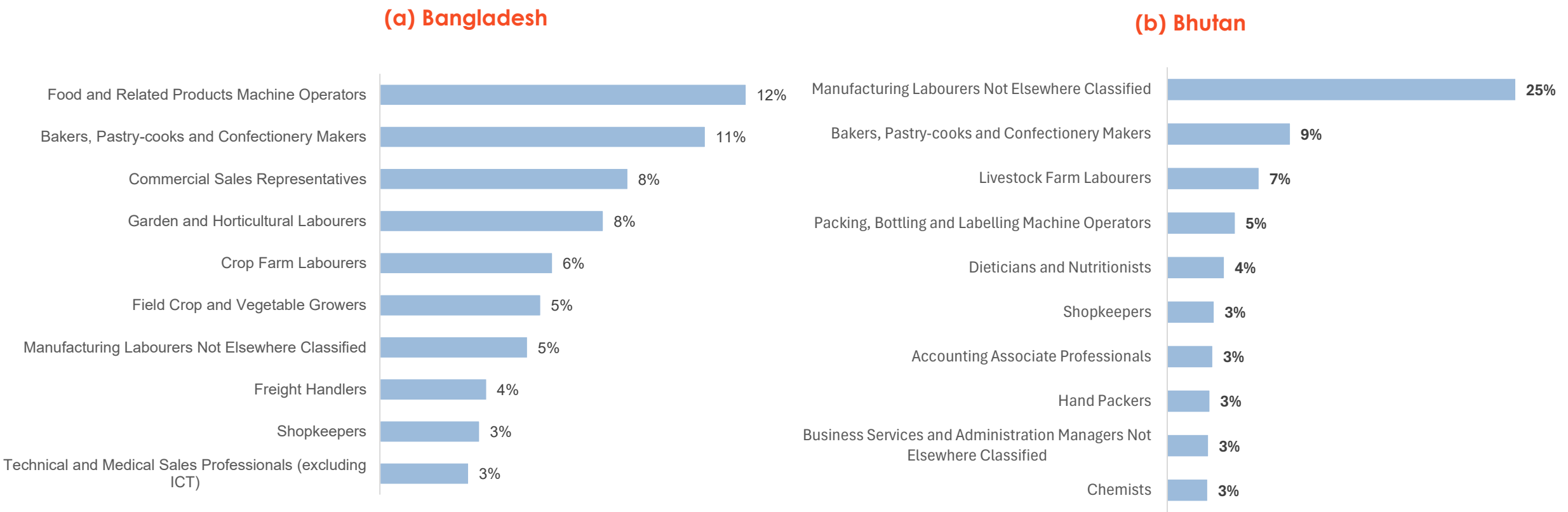
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## **Food processing occupations with high employment generation**

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Food processing employment in Bangladesh and Bhutan is concentrated across production, processing, machine operation, sales, and laborer roles. This points to the need for practical training that combines core technical food-processing skills with workplace logistics and basic business skills.

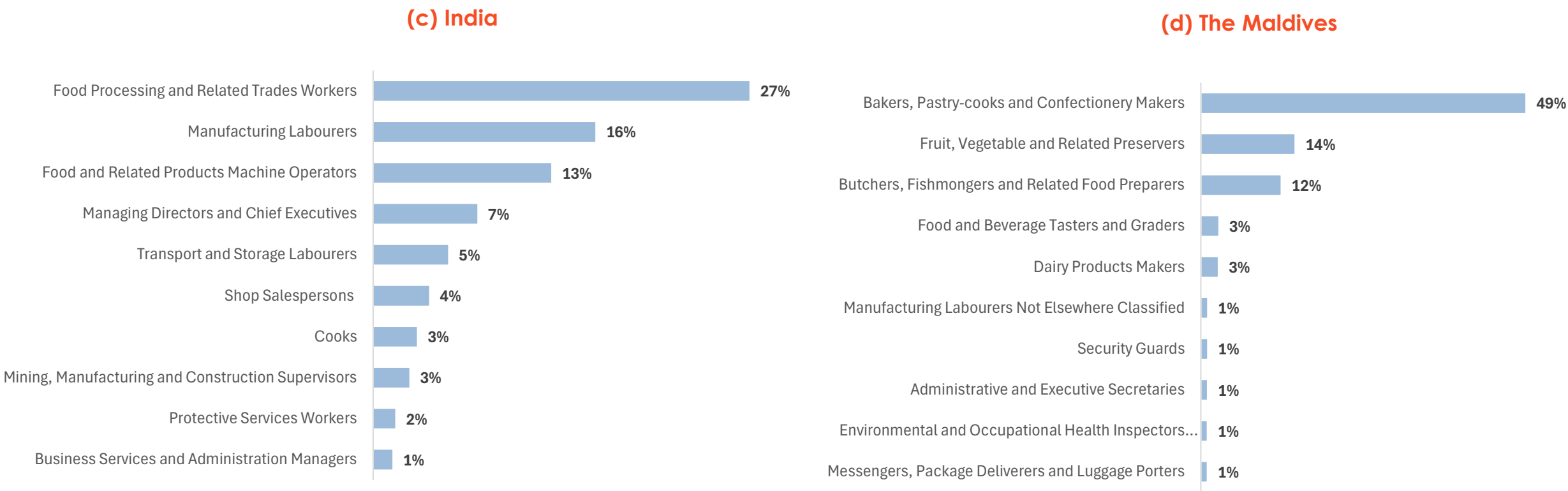
Top ten food processing occupations in each country in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country. The percentages reported for each occupation represent their contribution to the country's food processing workforce.

India and the Maldives show more concentrated food processing employment around core production occupations. In India, food processing trades, manufacturing laborers, and machine operators dominate, while in Maldives, bakers and food preparation occupations account for a particularly large share of employment.

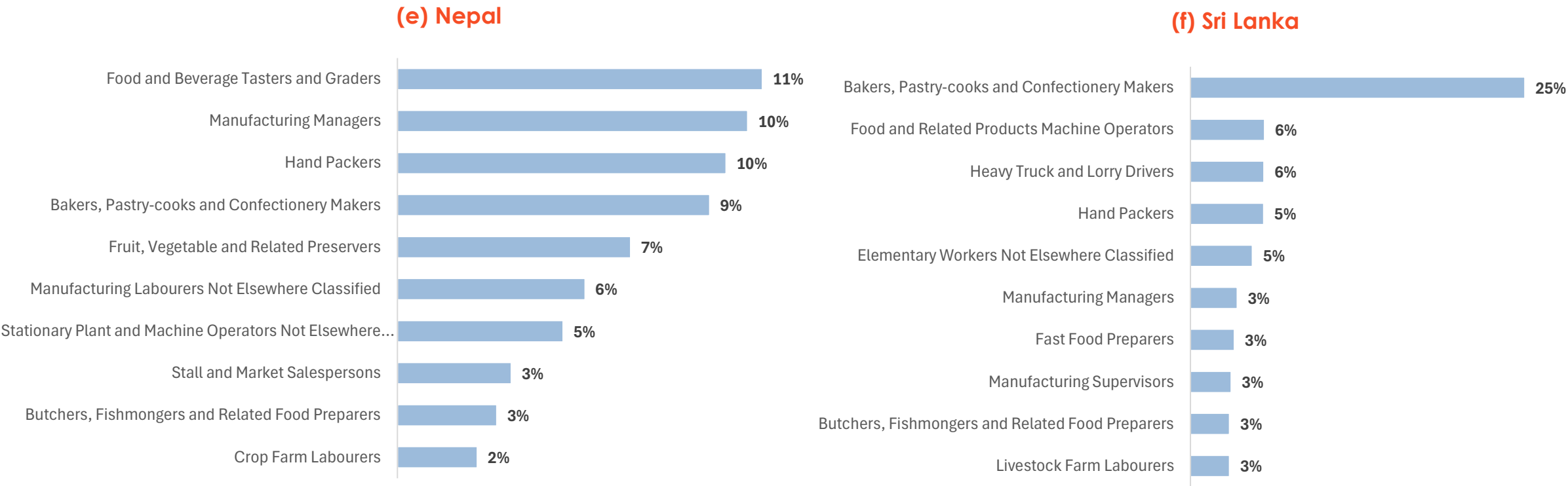
Top ten food processing occupations in each country in South Asia, circa 2023



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Nepal and Sri Lanka also show strong concentration in a few food processing occupations, but with different profiles. Nepal combines quality-control, management, packing, and bakery-related roles, while Sri Lanka is more heavily concentrated in bakery, machine-operation, transport, packing, and supervisory occupations.

Top ten food processing occupations in each country in South Asia, circa 2023



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the Bangladesh QLFS (2022), Bhutan LFS (2022), India PLFS 2023/24, Maldives HIES (2019), Nepal LSS 2022/23, and Sri Lanka LFS (2023). The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). The South Asia regional average is estimated using equal weights for each country. The percentages reported for each occupation represent their contribution to the country's food processing workforce.

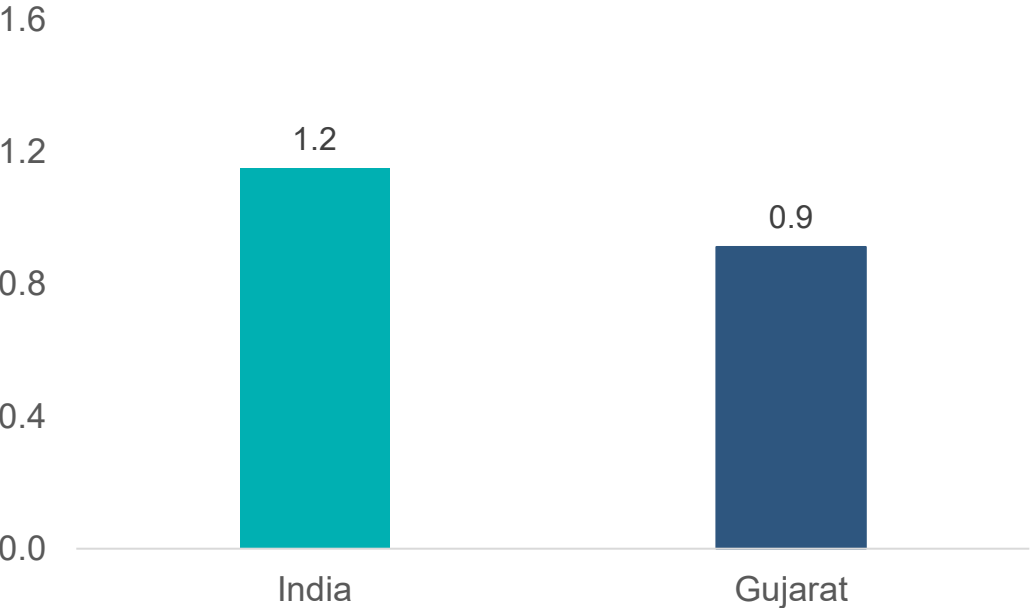
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# **Food processing workers in Gujarat, India**

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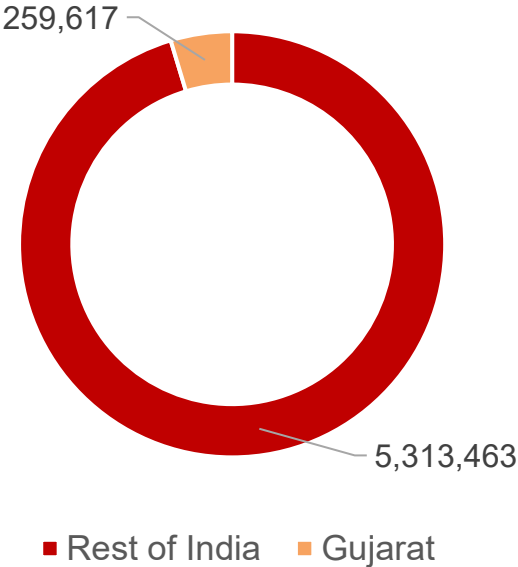
Food processing accounts for a smaller share of total employment in Gujarat than in India overall, employing 260,000 workers in the state.

Percentage of workers in food processing in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

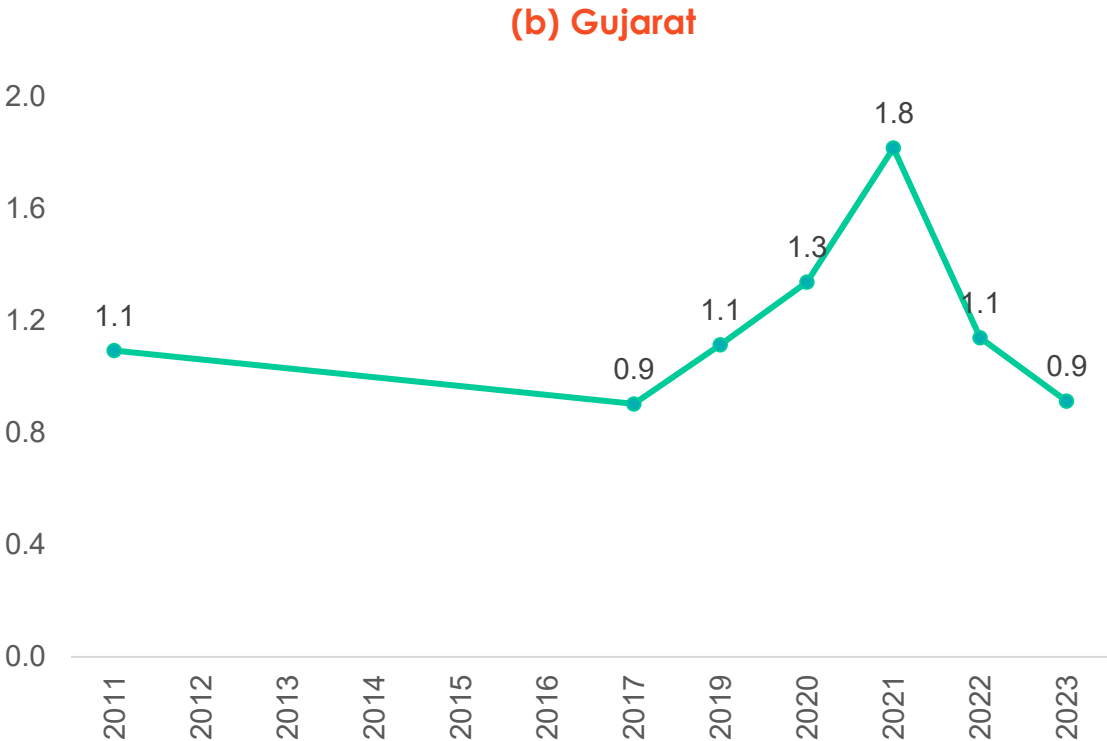
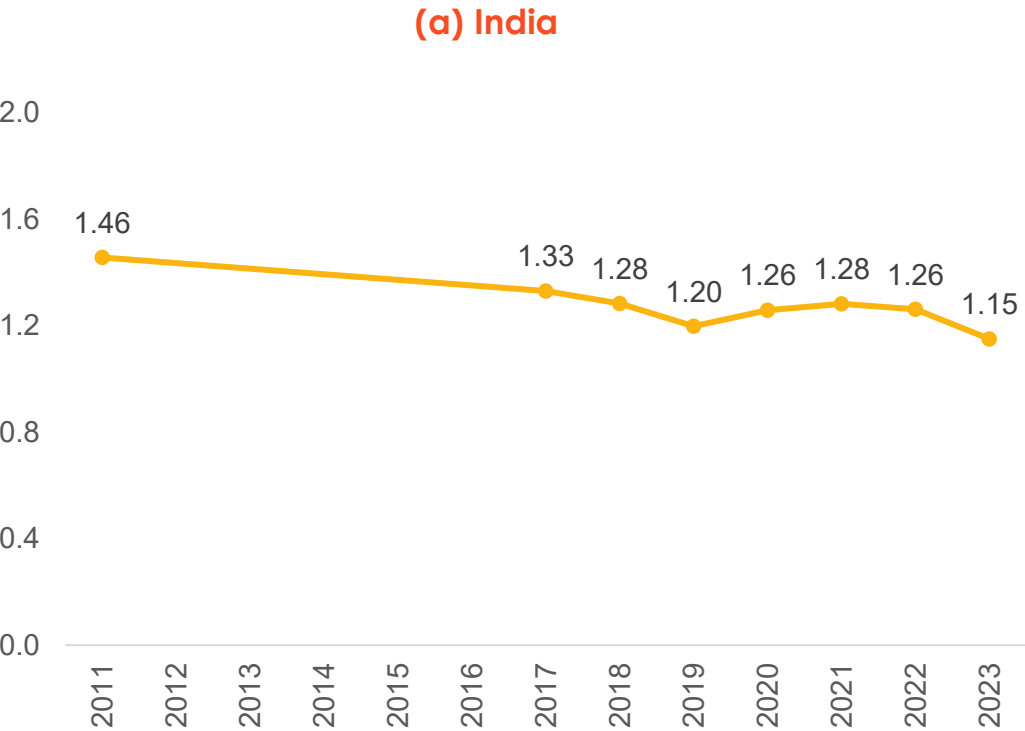
Number of workers in the food processing sector in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

Food processing employment is modest in both India and Gujarat, but Gujarat experienced a temporary expansion between 2017 and 2021 before falling below its 2011 level by 2023.

Share of food processing employment in Gujarat and All-India (%), 2011-2023



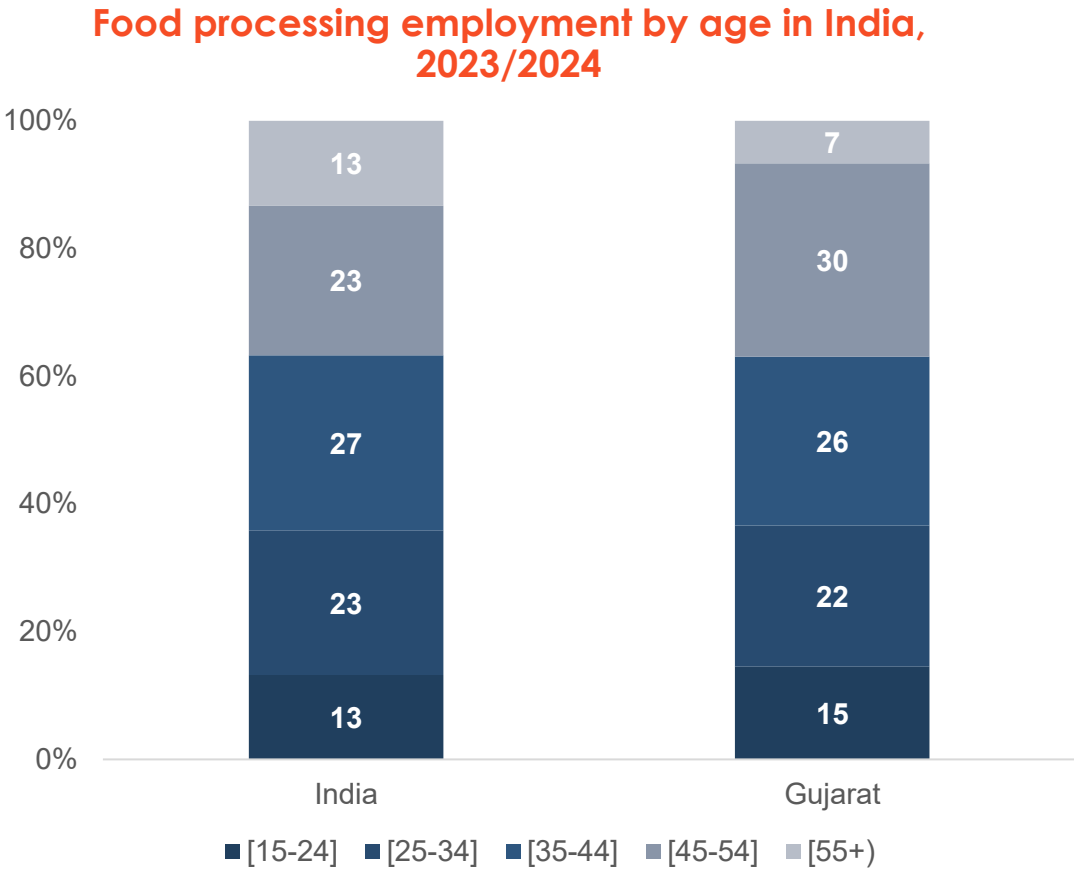
**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from for India’s Employment and Unemployment Survey for 2011/12 and Periodic Labour Force Surveys from 2017/18 to 2023/24. . The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).



Compared with India as a whole, Gujarat’s food processing workforce has a slightly higher female share and has a very similar age structure of workers as the rest of India.



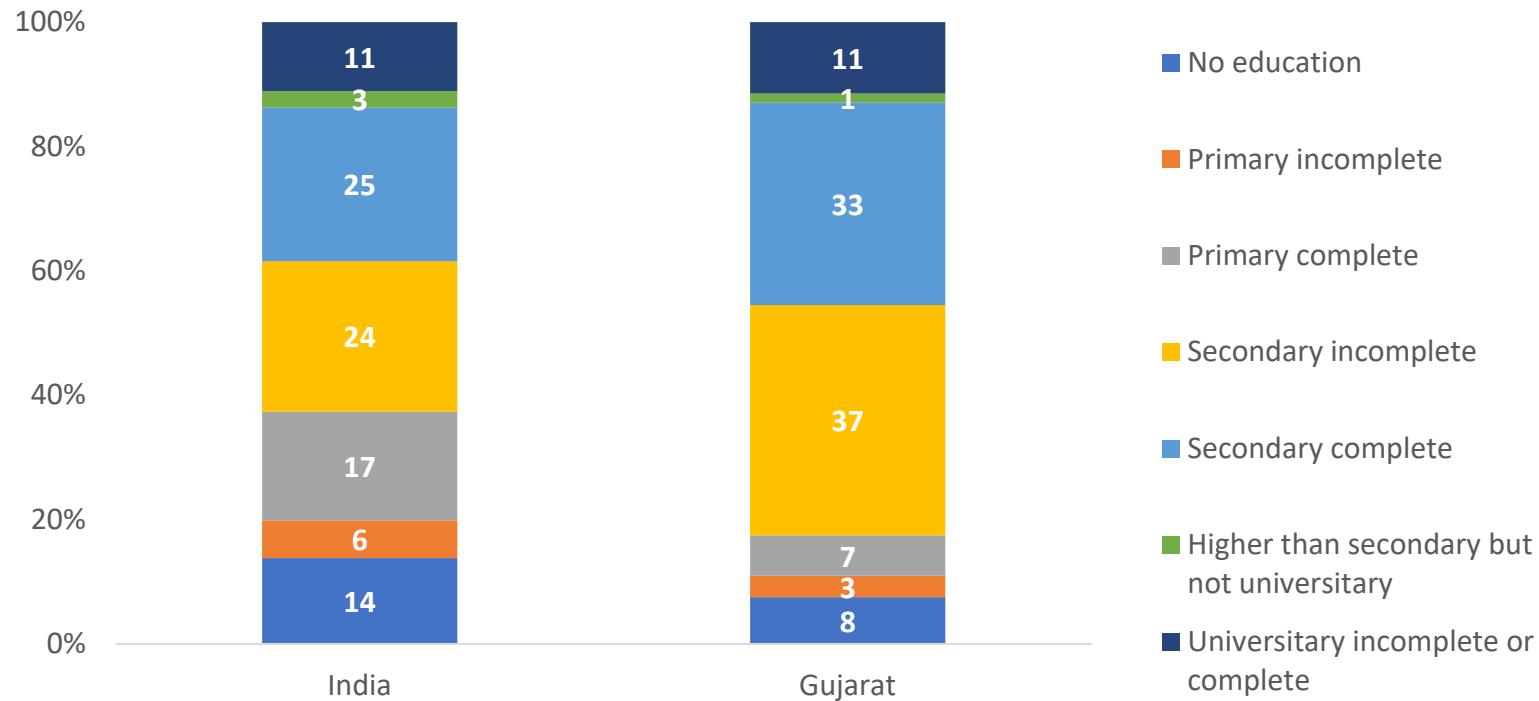
**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

**Compared with India overall, Gujarat's food processing workforce has a larger concentration of workers with secondary education and fewer workers with primary education or less, suggesting a relatively stronger basic education profile.**

**Food processing employment by educational attainment in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024**



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

Unlike the all-India pattern, Gujarat's food processing workforce is predominantly urban, with 66 percent of workers based in urban areas compared with 40 percent nationally.

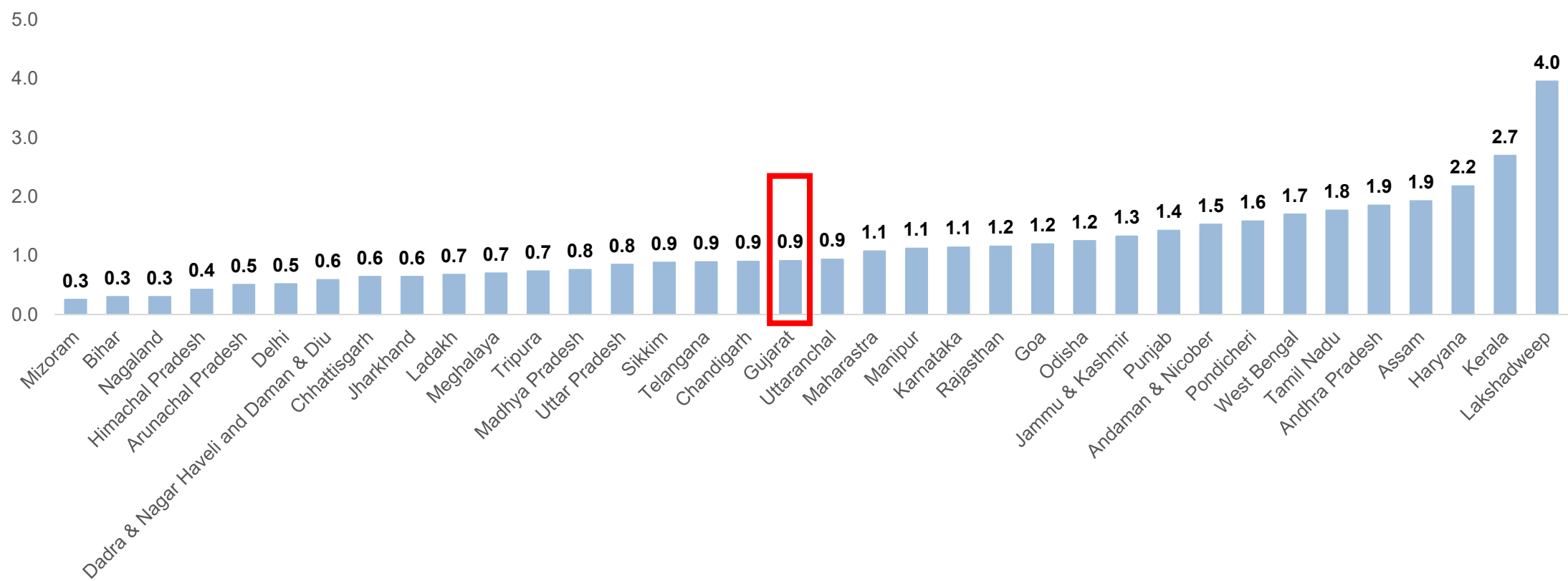
Food processing employment by place of residence in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises the manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

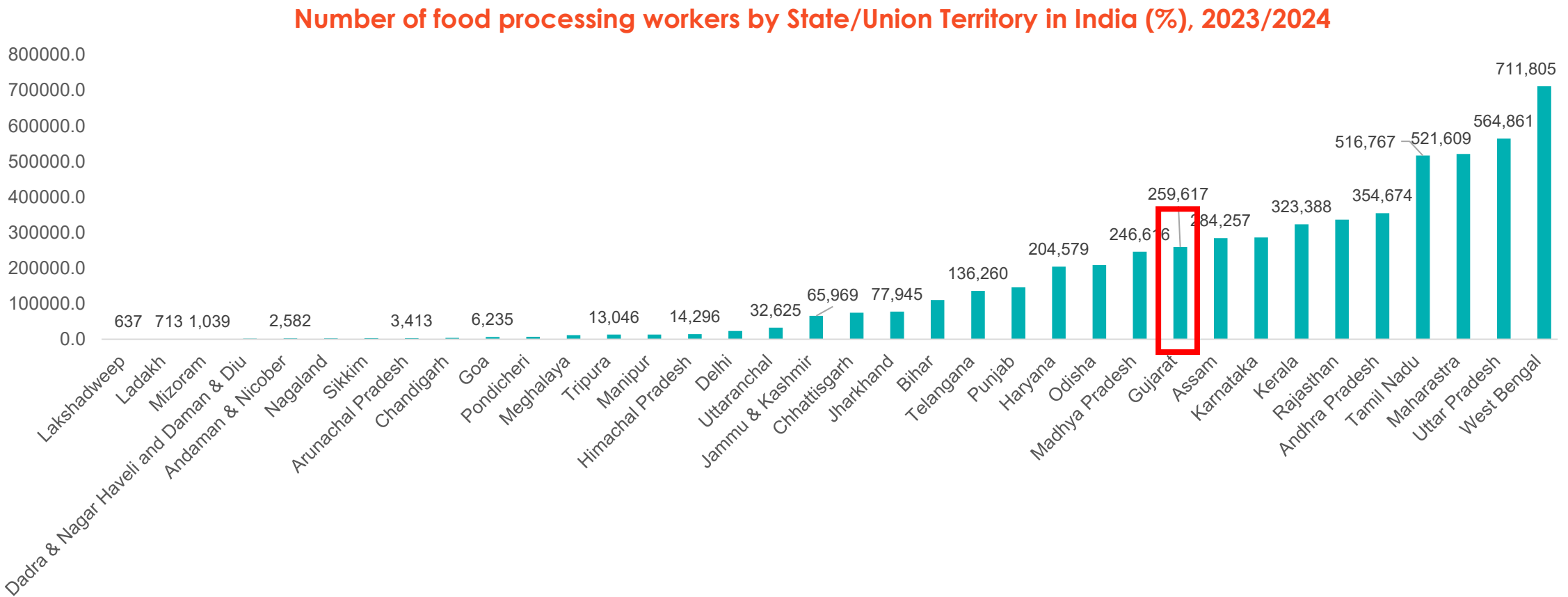
Gujarat’s food processing employment share is below the All-India average and sits toward the lower-middle of the state distribution, suggesting that the sector remains relatively small in the State despite the state’s broader industrial profile.

Share of food processing employment by State/Union Territory in India (%), 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

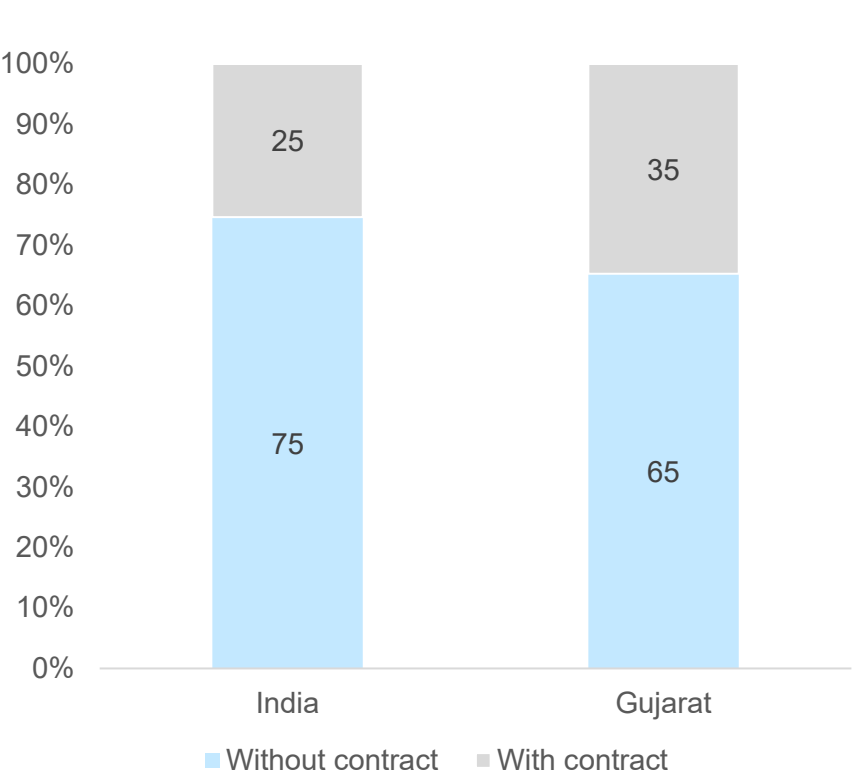
Yet, Gujarat has a sizeable food processing workforce in absolute terms, even though the sector represents a relatively small share of total state employment.



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

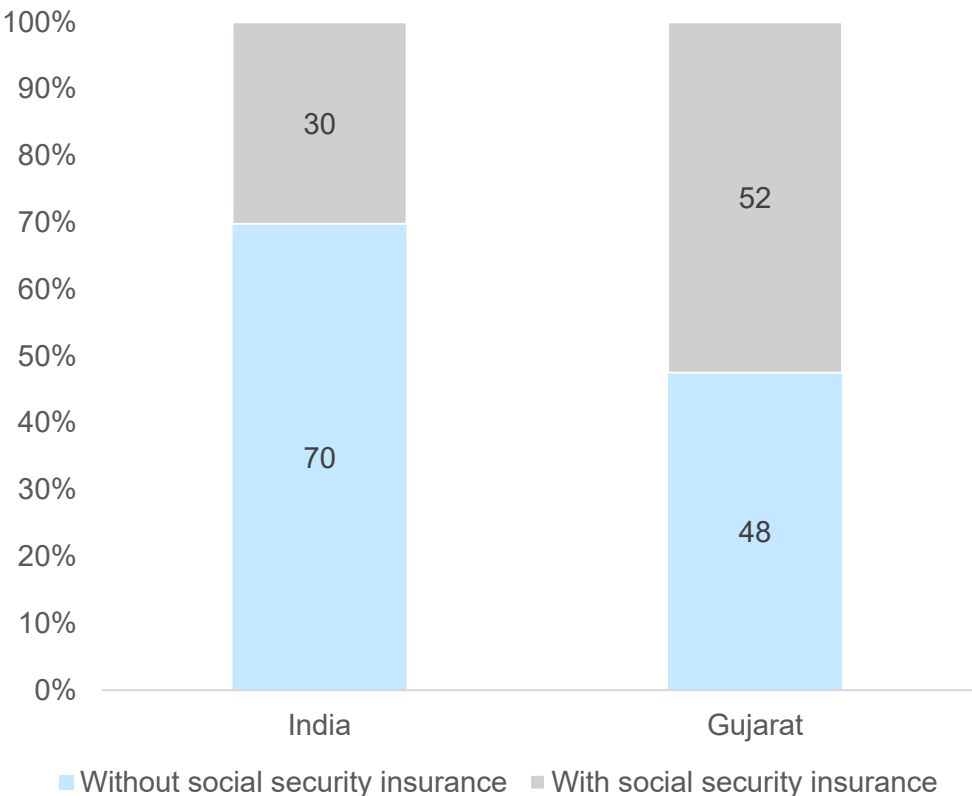
Food processing jobs in Gujarat appear somewhat more formal than other jobs, with higher shares of contracts and social security coverage compared to All-India.

Food processing employment by presence of labor contract in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

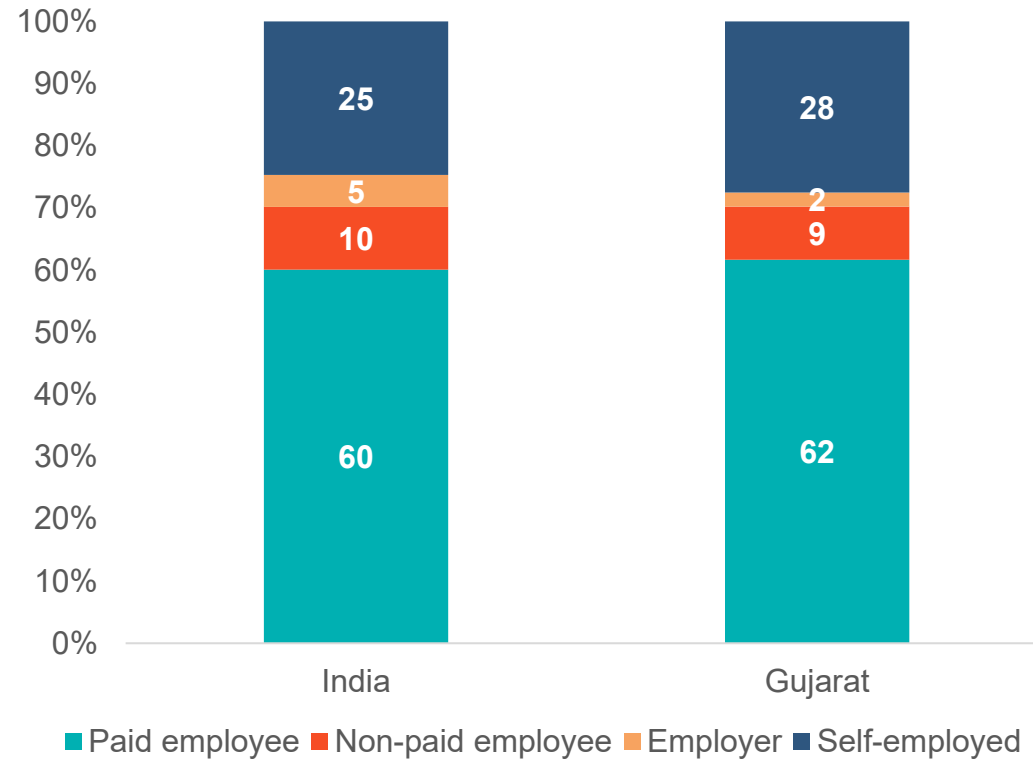
Food processing employment by social security insurance in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

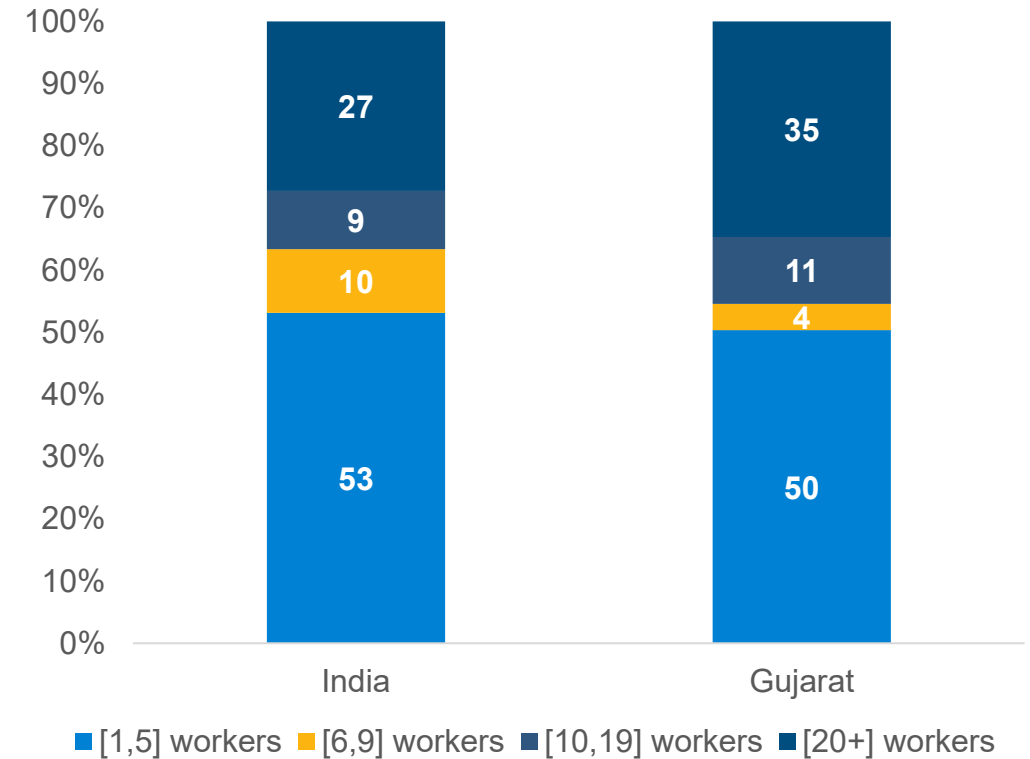
## Gujarat's food processing sector resembles the all-India pattern in employment status, but has a higher share of workers in larger firms, suggesting relatively greater formal or organized-sector presence.

Food processing employment by employment status in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

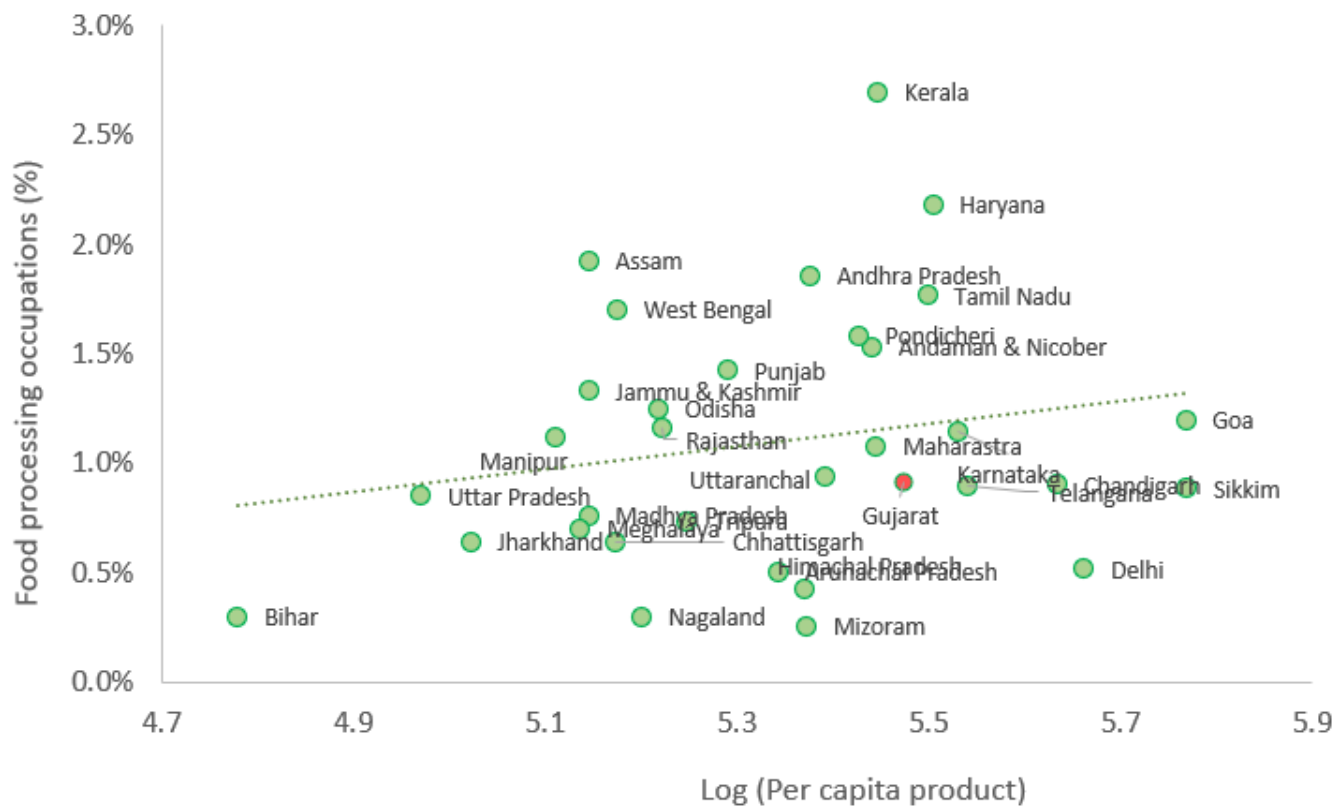
Food processing employment by firm size in Gujarat and All-India, 2023/2024



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11).

Food processing is more prominent in higher-income states. Gujarat has a relatively high income per capita but a below-trend share of food processing employment, suggesting scope to expand the sector relative to the state's economic potential.

Percentage of food processing occupations and per capita net domestic product at state/union territory level, 2023/24



**Source:** Own elaboration based on microdata from the 2023/24 Periodic Labour Force Survey for India and Per Capita Net State Domestic Product in 2023-24 from Reserve Bank of India. The food processing sector comprises manufacturing of food products and beverages (ISIC divisions 10–11). Average hourly wages of non-food and food processing occupations are respectively estimated as the constant and the coefficient of a linear regression of hourly wages on the food processing job variable.